CHAPTER THIRTY-FIVE

VIGNETTES OF AN UNCOMMON MAN

Minimalistic Living

Unlike most top-level industrialists or high-profile achievers, Ratan leads a simple life, shorn of ostentatiousness. From the clothes he wears to the watch on his wrist, everything he owns is remarkable for its simplicity. The watch incidentally is a basic one of a Swiss make that would be worth about Rs 5,000. His clothes are simple in style as well. Sunil Bharti Mittal comments that Ratan 'lives a simple life and is an example to many of us'.

However, when it comes to formal wear, his suits are generally sourced from Brioni, New York. He also normally buys his shoes from the US as he wears an American size 13.5, which is difficult to find in India. When not wearing formals, he wears denims and checked shirts stitched for him by his favourite tailoring shop in Mumbai, New York Tailors, which is located close to his house in Colaba.

Ratan has some fads too; his obsession with checked shirts is one. When he is not wearing his formals or business suits, he is more often than not spotted wearing them, as is evident from nearly 90 per cent of the photos taken when he is not in his formals, whether as a boy or in his adult years.

Ratan's choice of residence also reflects his simple ways. He has always stayed in a modest accommodation after his grandmother passed away. His three-bedroom flat in Bakhtavar where he stayed after his return from Jamshedpur in the late 1960s and where he continued to live until he retired as chairman, Tata Sons, could scarcely accommodate his needs. It was a 'book-crammed, dog-filled bachelor flat', wrote the *Financial Times* in 2007. Yet he was happy staying there for over four decades.

After his retirement, Ratan moved to Halekai, his retirement home, a stone's throw from his old flat in Bakhtavar. Halekai has been constructed